

World War II

Origins in Europe, 1936-1941

The origins and unfolding of the Second World War had very little to do with the United States. The World War II memorial in Washington, DC gives the dates of the war as “1941-1945.” Though those were the years of direct U.S. participation in the military conflict, the war in Europe was well underway long before the U.S. was even a factor.

Contrary to Hollywood-generated mythology that presents the war as almost solely an American triumph, the Soviet Union bore the brunt of the Nazi war machine, and its armed forces – assisted by U.S. aid – deserve much of the credit for breaking the back of the Third Reich.

In many respects the Second World War was simply a continuation of the First World War.

The Treaty of Versailles (1919) may have ended hostilities, but it did not entirely resolve the underlying sources of conflict. German resentment over the Treaty in part set the stage for the emergence of Adolf Hitler. (Similarly, Japanese resentment of the Treaty terms partially explain the origins of the war in Asia.)

Hitler and his National Socialist (Nazi) Party stoked feelings of resentment among many in the German middle classes who had

suffered economically and psychologically in the wake of World War I. He rode this resentment to power in 1933.

Hitler also co-opted the Allies' "self-determination" rhetoric to make the case for mobilizing German military power and expanding the German borders (seeking "lebensraum"). Citing U.S. President Woodrow Wilson who had preached that all peoples should have a government of their own choosing that represented the people's interests, Hitler set his sights on gathering all German speakers under the sovereignty of the German government.

This began with the re-occupation of the Rhineland in March 1936. Hitler demanded that French and British troops withdraw and allow the Germans who lived in this region full sovereignty.

Determined to avoid another conflict and preoccupied with domestic economic problems, London and Paris agreed to withdraw. Hitler soon began to use the natural and industrial resources now back under German control to fuel his military machine.

Two years later, in March 1938, Hitler negotiated the "Anschluss" ("Connection") between Germany and Austria. This move, he claimed, was not aggressive or expansionist but merely made legal the cultural reality – the Austrians and the Germans were one people (or so Hitler believed).

The West registered only a muted protest since Hitler justified his actions based on the self-determination ideology that the Western nations themselves had embraced.

Many Austrians (though certainly not all) welcomed the Anschluss, believing that they would benefit from German protection. Jews, of

course, were the notable exception. It soon became clear that the Nazis were a threat to them since they did not consider them “German,” but rather of some inferior race whose influence had to be curbed, if not eliminated.

Six months later, Hitler met with the leaders of France, Great Britain, and Italy in Munich. There, he promised them that his goals were limited – to bring German speaking peoples under German control. Once he had achieved this, he would forego any further expansion.

The governments of France and England chose to “appease” Hitler, not because they trusted his word, but because they knew they were in no position to defeat the Germans in a war. First, the Germans were stronger militarily; and second, public opinion was so anti-war that even attempts to mobilize for a potential war could get the ruling parties voted out of office.

British Prime Minister Neville Chamberlain came to be the “face” of appeasement and his ever-present umbrella its symbol. History has not been kind to Chamberlain. Many later accused him of cowardice and naivete; but his policies were more realistic and less cowardly than some of his critics have claimed. Through signing the Munich Agreement (and appeasing Hitler), Chamberlain believed he was “buying time” for the British to mobilize so that when the time came to face the Germans on the battlefield, the British armed forces would have a better chance of success.

Less than a month after the Munich Agreement, Hitler’s forces moved into the Sudetenland – a region of Czechoslovakia in which German speakers were numerous (but also a region in which some non-German speakers resided.) Again, Hitler justified his move in terms of “self-determination” – the German speakers had a right to be ruled by a German government.

A look at the map, however (See Powerpoint slide), shows that Hitler was positioning his troops to take over all of Czechoslovakia. The Czechs saw the writing on the wall and desperately appealed to Great Britain and France to protect them. They got no response.

All the while, Stalin in the Soviet Union was watching the unfolding of events. He urged the Western governments to join the Soviet Union in pursuing a policy of “Collective Security” in opposition to Hitler. London and Paris showed little interest in Stalin’s strategy.

Stalin concluded the Western governments were weak and would do (and could do) nothing to stop Hitler. He also suspected he was being set up – by “appeasing” the German leader as he cast his eyes toward the east, the West (or so Stalin believed) was indirectly urging Hitler to attack the Soviet Union.

By mid-1939 Stalin abandoned his efforts to join with the West in Collective Security and was looking for other options.

Meanwhile, Hitler was laying out his plans. Determined not to fight a two-front war, he indicated his willingness to sign a non-aggression pact with the Soviets, despite the fact that the Soviet Union had been ardently anti-Nazi in its rhetoric (and Hitler had been ardently anti-communist in his rhetoric).

Putting aside ideological differences for military and strategic considerations, the Germans and the Russians sign the **Nazi-Soviet pact** in August 1939.

This agreement immediately puts Poland in jeopardy. (Russia in the East; Germany in the West – see map on the Powerpoint slides – both threatened to invade.) The French and British governments

announce that if Germany attacks Poland, this will force them to declare war on Germany. Germany is not intimidated. Hitler's armies invade Poland on September 1, 1939.

Additionally, Soviet troops moved to occupy the eastern half of Poland (in part to expand Soviet influence but also to create a fortified buffer zone between the German army and Soviet territory.)

The Poles fought valiantly but were quickly vanquished by the superior German forces. (That the Poles sent men armed with sabers on horseback into the teeth of the German tanks is an exaggeration, but the fact remains that the Poles were no match for Hitler's Blitzkrieg.)

Having conquered the western half of Poland and insured that the Soviets would not move against German forces from the east, Hitler turns his attention once again to the west.

In 1940, his troops rapidly defeat the armed forces of Belgium, the Netherlands, Norway, and Luxemburg. Next in his path is France, which falls in June 1940. The world sees the grim images of Nazi troops marching down Paris's Champs Elysees.

The French had a substantial and well-equipped army, so the French defeat at the hands of the Nazis came as a great shock – particularly given how quickly it occurred.

British troops sent to supplement the French forces beat a hasty retreat after the battle of Dunkirk in northern France. Most made it safely back across the English Channel insuring the British would survive to fight another day, but British Prime Minister Winston Churchill (who replaced Neville Chamberlain in 1940) reminds his people that “wars are not won by evacuations.”

Hitler, pressing his advantage, begins an aerial bombardment of British cities (especially London). The Brits vow to fight on. Queen Elizabeth (mother of the current queen) announces her children will stay with her; she will stay with the King; and the King “will never leave” London. Churchill speaks to the nation from underground – “We will never surrender.”

The British Royal Air Force outfought the German Luftwaffe and Hitler paused his attack. The Germans come close, but they are unable to deliver a knock out blow to the British.

At this point, Hitler makes the first of two colossal blunders that will ultimately lose him the war. Rather than continuing to focus on defeating the British, he assumes that they are so close to defeat that he can finish them off later. Instead, he mobilizes his forces to attack the Soviet Union.

Churchill and U.S. President Franklin D. Roosevelt warn Stalin that the Germans are preparing to invade his country. Stalin, wary of the deceptive ways of “capitalists and imperialists,” ignores the warnings....until it is too late.

Even worse, during the previous year Stalin had conducted a ferocious purge of Soviet generals and other senior officers. At the very moment when war against Germany loomed, Stalin was decimating the upper ranks of his military.

On June 22, 1941 German troops crossed into Soviet territory. Unprepared and ill-equipped, Soviet troops were no match for heavily armed, mechanized German tank divisions. The Soviets, some fighting with broom sticks, were mercilessly slaughtered. Wave after wave of Soviet infantry are thrown at the advancing

German line. Over the next two years, the Germans march relentlessly across Soviet territory (the same distance as if they had landed on the east coast of the U.S. and marched as far as Chicago). Those Soviet troops who try to retreat are shot down by the Soviet secret police (NKVD). By the end of the war, the NKVD had killed a million Soviet citizens who tried to flee the German advances. Overall, the Soviets lose more than 20 million people.

In time, however, Hitler's forces would fall victim to the same Russian winter that had thwarted Napoleon Bonaparte's ill-fated invasion more than a century before. The tide would turn and the Soviets would go on the offensive, not stopping until they had marched all the way to Berlin – where they arrived in the summer of 1945.